

All Areas

2021- 2022

Burning Man's Socially Engaged Event (2420CI132A)

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Intro

Entrepreneurship is characterized as “the pursuit of opportunity beyond the resources currently controlled”. (Miller, 2020)

In this Infographic, we will be taking a look at; 1- components of fruitful entrepreneurship in the events industry, 2- corporate social responsibility (CSR) analysis and its latest trends, 3- exploring a new potential aim for the Burning Man event, a potential partner to the event and estimating the risks involved.

1. Elements of Successful Entrepreneurship in The Events Industry

The entrepreneur characteristics are described as “Dynamism, ambition, passion for great products, purity of thought; stubbornness” (Turner, 2014)

Entrepreneurship comes along with a set of different skills and aspects to excel in the events industry or any industry, however, the focus of this infographic is going to be the events industry. Let's take a look at some of these essential key elements that are a game-changer;

1.1 Basic Aspect: Market research

This is the basis of success. It is linked with all of the aspects listed below. Conducting research not only help us understand opportunities and risks but also “runs meaningful tests to validate your idea and determine whether it has potential.” (Miller, 2020)

In the following aspects, research is required and almost always takes place;

1.2 Aspect #1: Understand The Audience

Identifying and analyzing the target audience is deemed a crucial and essential step in the event market. From choosing the appropriate communication channels to deciding on the right venue and other criteria. (Targosz, 2018)

Through quantitative research, we can understand basic demographic data of the target audience, their interests or needs, and their habits. That is key for successful entrepreneurship in the event market.

By understanding our target audience we make sure to remember there are always risks involved and not be solely motivated by money but also take our audience as the whole reason why the event is taking place.

1.3 Aspect #2: Staying Up To Date aka. Risk Resistant

As we have experienced in 2020/2021 certain unexpected events as health pandemics could be very detrimental to the event market as many events had to shut down. (Christl, 2021)

Staying up to date has always been beneficial within any industry but especially the events industry. By making sure we as entrepreneurs avoid the risk of having to physically shut our created events down, there are new technological opportunities in the market to take advantage of. Some of these are Virtual Reality and Augmented Reality which allows event entrepreneurs to create completely remote events or the so-called hybrid events in which partially remote events take place. An audience can interact and virtually exist at a certain event even during lockdowns when many events usually decide to shut down. (Soltis, 2019)

Other technological opportunities within the event market are; Radio Frequency Identification, a technology that allows the audience to communicate with each other at the event.

Event Analytics helps to evaluate all types of data generated by any event.

Hyper-Targeting On Social Media, using social media at events is not necessarily all that new, however, more targeted social media strategies have emerged where event creators can obtain geographical data from Facebook for instance. “We need to embrace the new opportunities that technology” (Jenkins, 2014)

1.4 Aspect #3: Resilience and Durability

In entrepreneurship, it is relatively straightforward to start an event business concept, however, one must think about sustainability in the long term “Entrepreneurship is a long-term endeavor, and entrepreneurs must focus on the process from beginning to end to be successful in the long run.” (Miller, 2020)

Many events got canceled in the covid-19 health pandemic, therefore, they were not resilient enough to stay durable, some of these events are Tomorrowland, Burning Man, Mysteryland, including many sports events, and various other types of events. Health pandemics are not the only reason why an event stops from being held, loss of reputation, damage to facilities, economy whether global or local, laws, and trend changes are more examples of potential risks that directly impact durability.

Conducting risk assessments helps to make sure an event stays durable and resilient to sudden or long term changes in the industry (Howard, 2020)

More examples of Elements of Successful Entrepreneurship include “Curiosity, Structured Experimentation, Adaptability, Decisiveness, Team Building, Risk Tolerance, Comfortable with Failure, Persistence, Innovation”. (Miller, 2020)

2. Elements of Sustainable Entrepreneurship

2.1 Definition

The general definition of Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) is that it's an administrative concept that it's based on the hypothesis "good business for a good society today and tomorrow" It is about regulating ethically how corporations make a profit but not how they spend it thus, it is not about charity work. It takes genuine and suitable organizational structures to make CSR happen as it tests the ethics of an individual (consumer responsibility) as much as of an institution. Politics can be the main key at play to how and what drives CSR to take place (2012, October 1)

According to the Netherlands Enterprise Agency, CSR also means being held responsible for the impact of a business on human beings, the environment, and society as a whole. Ben & Jerry's and Nike are two examples of corporations applying effective CSR by having withdrawn from selling their products on occupied Palestinian land in 2021 (Petter, 2021)

2.2 CSR: In The Event Industry

Inspired by The UN's 17 Goals For Sustainable Development for 2030 (2016) In the event business, CSR entails;

- paying attention to working conditions with regards to safety, work time/salary ratio, general well-being
- creating sustainable events that do not increase CO2 emissions or be wasteful as in; creating plastic waste, wastewater
- being inclusive
- being innovative

2.3 Examples and Latest Trends in 2021

Transparency

Searching for the truth and authenticity is at its highest peaks of demand in 2021. People are asking corporations to be more transparent with them about what goes on in decision making, activities, and policies for instance. In the Netherlands, the Ministry of Economic Affairs comes out with a bi-annual study, known as the Transparency Benchmark which aims to calculate their transparency in reporting on corporate social responsibility.

This trend is highly promising since too often, companies attempt to change perceptions without changing facts (Hess, 2007) therefore, corporations are at risk of falling into scandals. Being transparent, realistic, honest when applied in CSR policies can be a very good opportunity to gain the target audience's trustworthiness.

Virtual Community Engagement

At end of 2020, corporations started adapting to the aftermath of lockdowns by joining multiple platforms to virtually cooperate for their communities, employees, and brand. Non-profit organizations turned to apply the concept of virtual volunteering.

The 'work from home culture' has emerged. Therefore, "virtual initiatives & virtual volunteering gained pace. The trend is expected to grow this year and, most likely, in 2022 as well." (Natalia, 2021)

This trend is highly promising due to increasing the resistance to potential lockdowns or something of the sort. People can still engage and communities can still be well managed.

Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion

This is one of the trends that has been on the rise for a while but in 2021, the need for real measurable actions towards equality and inclusion has never reached this peak. According to RSM (2018) "Diversity and inclusion: Hand-in-hand with CSR". There are no risks associated with following this trend. However, there are lots of promises; as according to the study held by RSM; it reinforces the organization's values. Moreover, it improves employee collaboration and ensures a positive work environment.

Focus on Healthcare

October 10th, World Mental Health Day (WMHD) will provide a chance for a bigger conversation on the emphasis of mental health and well-being, not solely in the workplace, but as a crucial part that businesses must implement in their CSR strategies. (McClimon, 2021)

3. New Aim – Burning Man

Burning Man has many purposes such as “celebrating creativity, self-expression, cultural differences, knowledge sharing, releasing social stigma, and so much more” (Wathen, 2018)

However, since in our Brand Positioning report, we proposed that event can work on one key goal which is making the event is meant for Everyone. This will be the new highlighted purpose for Burning Man in 2022. After 2 years of the event being canceled, one way to come back to the target audience is by making a big emphasis on how inclusive the event is. Inclusivity and equity are at the core of Burning Man’s values.

The current price for tickets at the event range between 475 U.S Dollars and go up to as high as 1,400\$.

In 2014, Burning Man has been granted the status of a non-profit organization (March 3, The Burning Man Project) Therefore, as an NPO, their new purpose for 2022 must include but is not limited to;

- lowering down the prices,
- giving discounts for students, teachers...etc.
- creating non-biased financial aid programs to help attendees raise funds to buy their tickets on the event’s website or even equipment budget to help set up their camp at the event
- better treating employees
- more emphasis on inclusion and diversity

Back in 2016, Burning Man started a program of funding 4,000 people to get low incomers tickets to the event. However, a lot of people thought that the distribution of the tickets was not equal among applicants (Dane, 2016) Therefore, In 2022 the event’s purpose should clearly demonstrate its core value of inclusion and that everyone is indeed welcomed at the event regardless of income. This can be done by creating aid programs that help as many as 10,000 people in a fair system where applicants send in their applications and they get reviewed by a team of expertise in non-profit organization funding.

One of our contact persons noted that after having worked at the Burning Man Organization for 3 years, department of Public Affairs, he experienced a “very toxic work environment” and what he called “exploitation of seasonal workers” he further mentioned that he has quit the job ever since because he could not tolerate that work type environment anymore. (Intagriti, 2021)

Hence, the event must adopt new laws within the organization that ensures a healthy working environment “Healthy environment equals healthy business” (Pirri, 2015)

Gain

Following this new purpose will not only ensure an increase in the number of attendees at the event but also will improve Burning Man's reputation as a 'non-profit organization' and be a good comeback for the event in 2022 after its absence last couple of years. Furthermore, it will improve the well-being of the work environment at the event which will attract volunteers, interns, and paid employees.

Risk

The risks involved in the new purpose are only financial costs for instance in the ticket funding aid program or giving discounts for students and teachers. There is however no risk included in creating a healthier work environment and making a greater emphasis on inclusivity.

4. Partner

Microsoft will be a partner and a sponsor of the Burning Man event in 2022. Since Microsoft has a long history of being partners and or donating to non-profit organizations

In 2016, the company granted \$465 million in cloud services to more than 71,000 nonprofits. "Its Affordable Access Initiative is helping 11 countries connect rural schools, community centers, healthcare clinics and police stations to the internet." (Renjen, 2017)

Having Microsoft as a partner will entail for Burning Man the following:

- Provide the event with cloud services to run their online systems.
- Sponsor the 10,000 participants ticket aid program and perhaps increase the number of possible applicants to 20,000.
- Advertise for the Burning Man event on Microsoft products.

This partnership will be formed to be the positive type therefore it must be a win-win type of arrangement which means for Microsoft it will entail;

- Improved brand image in supporting an event like Burning Man which is all about equality and inclusivity (Microsoft has this also as one of their brand values)
- Microsoft will be collecting data on the attendees and the event as a whole which since they will utilizing their cloud services
- Since 78,850 people visited the event in 2019 alone, it is a big marketing opportunity for Microsoft to advertise for its newest Windows 11 operating system (and other products by the company) by setting up banners at the event

Having Microsoft as a partner to the event goes hand in hand with the purpose of Burning Man for 2022, Microsoft has a long history of supporting non-profits, and Burning Man requires that help in its 2022 new purpose which is aimed to allow as many people as possible to get the chance to visit the event. A core value that is at the essence of the Burning Man organization spirit.

Furthermore, another reason why this partnership could potentially be fruitful is that 'diversity and inclusion is one of the six brand values to Microsoft' (McIntyre, 2020) Thus, it is a good chance for the company to further highlight that through this partnership.

5. Determining Partnership Risks

“Finding a business partner is easy, but finding the right business partner is difficult.” (Sangha, 2021)

Partnerships often come with lots of risks as well, some of which are;

Risks for Burning Man

- Data collection leak of event attendees information for using Microsoft service clouds, this is quite risky especially since Burning Man attendees highly value their privacy.
- Attendees may not be quite satisfied with Microsoft's marketing for its products during the event since they do not deem it as the corporate type.

Risks for Microsoft

- The event is canceled, therefore, the loss of the funding to the tickets aid program.
- Microsoft may get media backlash for endorsing such events as Burning Man which is controversial in nature.

Lack of trust is also one of the many partnerships risks, for any relationship to function well, it demands trust. When it comes to working together, even bigger trust is needed at a larger scale. You're not only responsible for your own brand, you're also responsible for the with the consequences to your employees and clients just as much.

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